“Śrī Caitanya-caritāmṛta”

Madhya-līlā

Chapter 7

The Journey to the South: The Deliverance of Vāsudeva

(English translation from the Bengali, following the Gauḍīya Maṭha edition and the Anubhāṣya, 2026)

1 I praise that blessed Caitanya who, His heart melting with compassion, cured Vāsudeva of leprosy, filled him with beauty and made him content in devotion.[1]

2 Glory, glory to Śrī Caitanya! Glory to Nityānanda! Glory to Advaitacandra! Glory to all the devotees of Gaura![2]

3 Having thus delivered Sārvabhauma, the Lord felt the desire to go to the south.

4 The Lord accepted sannyāsa in the bright fortnight of Māgha, and in Phālguna He came to live in Nīlācala.

5 At the end of Phālguna He saw the Dola-yātrā festival and, absorbed in love, danced and sang in many ways.

6 Staying on through Caitra, He delivered Sārvabhauma; and at the beginning of Vaiśākha He resolved to go south.

7 He called His associates together, embraced them all, took them by the hand and spoke to them humbly:

8 “I know all of you to be dearer to Me than life itself. My life may leave Me, but I cannot leave you.

9 You are My friends, and you have done a friend’s duty: you brought Me here and showed Me Jagannātha.

10 Now I beg one gift of you all: with one accord give Me leave, and I shall go to the south.

11 I must certainly go in search of Viśvarūpa. I shall go alone and take no one with Me.[3]

12 Until I return from Setubandha, all of you should stay here in Nīlācala.”

13 The all-knowing Lord knew that Viśvarūpa had already attained perfection; He used the search only as a pretext to deliver the southern country.[4]

14 Hearing this, everyone was stricken with great sorrow. All fell silent, and their faces withered.

15 Nityānanda Prabhu said, “How can this be? You will go alone — who could bear it?

16 Let one or two of us go with You, so that You do not fall into the hands of rogues. Name any two, and let them go with You.[5]

17 I know all the routes to the holy places of the south. Let Me go with You, Prabhu — give Me Your permission.”

18 The Lord replied, “I am a dancer and You are the puppeteer. As You make Me dance, so I dance.[6]

19 After taking sannyāsa I set out for Vṛndāvana, but You led Me instead to Advaita’s house.

20 On the way to Nīlācala You broke My daṇḍa. The deep affection all of you bear for Me hinders My work.

21 Jagadānanda wants Me to enjoy worldly comforts, and whatever he says, I try to do out of fear.

22 If ever I go against his word, he is angry with Me and does not speak to Me for three days.

23 Mukunda is unhappy to see the duties of My sannyāsa: bathing three times a day even in the cold, and sleeping on the bare ground.

24 Mukunda grieves within but says nothing; and seeing his grief, I grieve twice as much.

25 I am a sannyāsī and Dāmodara a brahmacārī, yet he always stands over Me with the rod of instruction.[7]

26 In his eyes I know nothing of proper conduct, and My independent ways do not please him.

27 By Kṛṣṇa’s mercy he cares nothing for what people think; but I can never give up regard for what people think.

28 Therefore all of you stay in Nīlācala, while for some time I wander alone to the holy places.”

29 The Lord is controlled by the very qualities of these devotees, and in the guise of finding fault with them He relished their virtues.[8]

30 Caitanya's affection for His devotees is beyond words. He Himself endures the hardships of renunciation.

31 But when a devotee is pained to see those hardships, that pain He has no power to bear.

32 So, calling their virtues faults, He held them all back, for He meant to wander the holy places alone in strict renunciation.

33 Then the four devotees pleaded with Him at length, but the Lord, independent and supreme, would not consent.

34 Then Nityānanda said, "Whatever You order is My duty, whether it brings sorrow or happiness.

35 But I make one more request: consider it, and then accept it.

36 A kaupīna, an outer cloth and a water pot: that is all You will take with You, and nothing more.

37 Both Your hands are occupied in counting the holy names. How will You carry the water pot and the outer cloth?

38 On the way You will fall unconscious in the ecstasy of love. Who will look after these things of Yours then?

39 Here is a simple brāhmaṇa named Kṛṣṇadāsa. Please take him with You — grant My request.[9]

40 He will go with You and carry the water pot and the cloth. Do whatever You wish; he will say nothing."

41 The Lord then accepted His words and, taking them all along, went to Sārvabhauma's house.

42 Sārvabhauma bowed down and offered them seats; then, after greeting everyone, he sat down.

43 The Lord spoke with him of Kṛṣṇa in many ways and then said, "I have come to you to ask your permission.

44 Viśvarūpa took sannyāsa and went to the south, and I must go in search of him.

45 Give Me permission, for I must go to the south. By your leave I shall come back safely."[10]

46 Hearing this, Sārvabhauma was deeply distressed. Clasping the Lord's feet, he replied sorrowfully:

47 "By the piety of many births I obtained Your company, and now Providence is breaking it off.

48 If a thunderbolt struck my head or my son died, I could bear it; but separation from You I cannot bear.

49 You are the independent Lord, and You will go. But stay a few days, so that I may see Your feet."

50 His humble plea softened the Lord's heart, and He stayed on a few days instead of leaving.

51 The Bhaṭṭācārya insistently invited Him, had food cooked at home and fed the Lord.

52 His wife, known as "Ṣāṭhī's mother", cooked and served the Lord His meals. Her story is a wonderful one.[11]

53 I shall tell it in detail later on; now I relate the account of the Lord's journey to the south.

54 After staying five days with the Bhaṭṭācārya, the Lord Himself asked permission to set out.

55 At the Lord's insistence the Bhaṭṭācārya consented, and the Lord took him to the temple of Jagannātha.

56 After seeing Jagannātha, He asked the Deity for permission, and the priest brought the Lord a garland from the Deity as prasāda.

57 Receiving this garland of permission, Gaurahari bowed down in delight and set out joyfully for the south.

58 With the Bhaṭṭācārya and all His own people He walked around Jagannātha's temple and then departed.

59 On the road to Ālālanātha along the seashore, Sārvabhauma said to Gopīnātha Ācārya:[12]

60 "I have kept four sets of kaupīnas and outer cloths at home. Have them brought by a brāhmaṇa, together with prasāda."

61 Then Sārvabhauma, bowing at the Lord's feet, said, "Prabhu, be sure to grant my request.

62 Rāmānanda Rāya lives on the bank of the Godāvarī; he is the governor of Vidyānagara.[13]

63 Do not neglect him, thinking him a śūdra and a worldly man (*viṣayī*). At my request, be sure to meet him.[14]

64 He is the one man worthy of Your company; in all the world there is no devotee who relishes rasa (*rasika*) as he does.

65 In learning and in the rasa of devotion he has reached the limit of both. When You speak with him, You will know his greatness.

66 Not understanding his extraordinary words and actions, I used to mock him, knowing him to be a Vaiṣṇava.[15]

67 By Your grace I now understand who he truly is. Speak with him, and You will see how great he is."[16]

68 The Lord accepted his words and, bidding him farewell, embraced him.

69 "Worship Kṛṣṇa at home and bless Me, so that by your grace I may return to Nīlācala."[17]

70 With these words Mahāprabhu departed, and Sārvabhauma fell unconscious on the spot.

71 Paying no heed to him, the Lord went quickly on His way. Who can understand the heart and mind of Mahāprabhu?

72 Such is the nature of the hearts of great souls: they are soft as a flower and hard as a thunderbolt.

73 “Harder than a thunderbolt, softer than a flower — such are the hearts of extraordinary souls. Who can ever understand them?” (Uttara-rāma-carita, 3.27)[18]

74 Nityānanda Prabhu lifted the Bhaṭṭācārya up and sent him home with his men.

75 The devotees quickly came and joined the Lord, and then Gopīnātha arrived with the cloth and the prasāda.

76 Then the Lord came with them all to Ālālanātha, bowed down to the Deity and offered Him many prayers.

77 For some time He danced and sang, absorbed in love, and all the people who lived there came to see Him.

78 All around Him the people called out, “Hari! Hari!” and in their midst Gaurahari danced, absorbed in love.

79 His body was like gold, His garment the colour of dawn, and horripilation, tears, trembling and perspiration adorned Him.

80 The sight filled the people with wonder. Of all who came, no one went home.

81 Some danced, and some sang, “Śrī Kṛṣṇa! Gopāla!” Everyone — women, the old and children alike — was carried away on the tide of love.

82 Seeing this, Nityānanda Prabhu said to the devotees, “Further on there will be dancing like this in village after village.”

83 Much time had passed, yet the people would not leave. Then Nityānanda Gosāñi devised a plan.

84 He took the Lord away to perform His midday duties, and at this the people came running from all sides.

85 To perform Their midday duties They came to the temple of the Deity, let Their own people in and shut the outer gate.

86 Then Gopīnātha served the two Lords Their meal, and everyone shared and ate the Lord's remnants.

87 Hearing where He was, all the people came to the outer gate and raised a clamour, crying, "Hari! Hari!"

88 Then Mahāprabhu had the door opened, and the people came in joyfully and saw Him.

89 In this way people came and went until evening. Dancing and singing, they all became Vaiṣṇavas.

90 So He spent that night there with the devotees, rejoicing in talks about Kṛṣṇa.

91 In the morning He bathed and set out, bidding the devotees farewell with embraces.

92 They all fell to the ground unconscious, but the Lord did not turn back to look at them.

93 Agitated by the separation, the Lord went on in sorrow, and behind Him came Kṛṣṇadāsa carrying the water pot.

94 The devotees stayed there fasting, and the next day they returned to Nīlācala in sorrow.

95 The Lord went on like a maddened lion, absorbed in love, singing the saṅkīrtana of the holy name:

96 "O Kṛṣṇa! Kṛṣṇa! Kṛṣṇa! Kṛṣṇa! Kṛṣṇa! Kṛṣṇa! Kṛṣṇa! O Kṛṣṇa! Kṛṣṇa! Kṛṣṇa! Kṛṣṇa! Kṛṣṇa! Kṛṣṇa! Kṛṣṇa! Kṛṣṇa! Kṛṣṇa! Kṛṣṇa! Kṛṣṇa! Kṛṣṇa! Protect Me! Kṛṣṇa! Kṛṣṇa! Kṛṣṇa! Kṛṣṇa! Kṛṣṇa! Kṛṣṇa! Save Me! Rāma! Rāghava! Rāma! Rāghava! Rāma! Rāghava! Protect Me! Kṛṣṇa! Keśava! Kṛṣṇa! Keśava! Kṛṣṇa! Keśava! Save Me!"[19]

97 Reciting this verse, Gaurahari went along the road, and whenever He saw people on the way, He told them, "Say 'Hari! Hari!'"

98 Those people, maddened with love, would call out, "Hari! Kṛṣṇa!" and follow behind the Lord, thirsting to see Him.

99 After a while the Lord would stop, embrace them, invest them with His power and send them back.[20]

100 Each of them returned to his own village and constantly laughed, wept and danced, calling, "Kṛṣṇa!"

101 Whomever he met he would tell, "Chant the name of Kṛṣṇa!" — and in this way he made his whole village Vaiṣṇava.

102 All who came from other villages to see him were blessed by the sight of him and became like him.

103 Each of these went home and made the people of his own village Vaiṣṇavas, and people from yet other villages came, saw him and became Vaiṣṇavas.

104 They in turn went and taught in other villages, and in this way the whole of the south became Vaiṣṇava.

105 So, as He travelled, the Lord made Vaiṣṇavas of hundreds upon hundreds of people by embracing them.

106 In whichever village He stayed and took His meal in someone's house, all the people of that village came to see Him.

107 By the Lord's mercy they became mahā-bhāgavatas, and as ācāryas they all delivered the world.

108 He did this all the way to Setubandha, and through their connection with the Lord all the lands became Vaiṣṇava.

109 The power He had not shown in Navadvīpa He now revealed to deliver the southern country.[21]

110 Whoever worships the Lord receives His mercy, and only such a person accepts all these pastimes as true.

111 Whoever has no faith in these extraordinary pastimes is ruined both in this world and in the next.

112 I have told first how the Lord travelled; know that it was the same throughout His tour of the south.

113 Travelling on in this way, He came to Kūrma-sthāna. Seeing the Deity of Kūrma, He offered Him prayers and obeisances.[22]

114 Absorbed in love, He laughed and wept, danced and sang, and all who saw it were filled with wonder.

115 Hearing of this wonder, people came to see, and they were amazed at the Lord's beauty and love.

116 Just by seeing Him they became Vaiṣṇavas and called out, “Kṛṣṇa! Hari!” Absorbed in love, the people danced with their arms raised.

117 Having heard the name of Kṛṣṇa ceaselessly from others’ lips, these people in turn made all the other villages Vaiṣṇava.

118 In this way, one from another, the whole land became Vaiṣṇava, and a flood of the nectar of Kṛṣṇa’s name swept over the country.

119 After some time, when the Lord returned to outward consciousness, the servant of the Deity of Kūrma honoured Him greatly.

120 In every village He went to, it was the same. I have described it here in one place and shall not describe it again.

121 In Kūrma-sthāna there lived a Vedic brāhmaṇa named Kūrma, who invited the Lord with great faith and devotion.

122 He brought the Lord home and washed His feet, and he and his whole family drank that water.

123 With great affection he fed the Lord many kinds of food, and he and his family ate the Gosāñi’s remnants.

124 “Your lotus feet, on which Brahmā meditates — those same lotus feet have come in person to my house!

125 There is no telling the limit of my good fortune. Today my birth, my family and my wealth have become glorious.

126 Be merciful to me, Prabhu — let me go with You. I shall not be able to bear the waves of separation from You.”

127 The Lord said, “Never speak like that. Stay at home and chant the name of Kṛṣṇa constantly.[23]

128 Whomever you see, teach him about Kṛṣṇa. By My order become a guru and deliver this land.

129 Then the waves of worldly life will never obstruct you, and here, in this very place, you will have My company again.”

130 In whatever house the Lord took His meal, the host spoke in the same way, and the Lord gave him this same teaching.[24]

131–132 On the way, whenever He stayed at a village temple, He would take His meal in someone’s house; and with each such great soul, His host, He dealt just as He had with Kūrma. So He did everywhere, until the Gosāñi returned to Nīlācala.[25]

133 That is why I have described it here in detail; know that this is how the Lord acted everywhere.

134 He stayed there that night, and in the morning, after bathing, the Lord set out.

135 Kūrma followed the Lord a long way, until the Lord gently persuaded him to go home.

136 There was a noble brāhmaṇa named Vāsudeva. His whole body was rotting with leprosy and swarming with worms.

137 Whenever a worm slipped and fell from his body, he would pick it up and put it back in the same place.

138 At night he heard of the Gosāñi's arrival, and in the morning he came to Kūrma's house to see Him.

139 When he heard from Kūrma that the Lord had gone, he fell to the ground unconscious with grief.

140 He began to lament in many ways, and at that very moment the Lord came and embraced him.

141 At the Lord's touch his leprosy vanished together with his grief, and his body became beautiful and full of bliss.

142 Seeing the Lord's mercy, he was amazed. Holding the Lord's feet, he recited a verse and praised Him:

143 "Who am I, a poor and sinful man, and who is Kṛṣṇa, the abode of the goddess of fortune? Yet because I was born a brāhmaṇa, He embraced me in His arms!" (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 10.81.16)[26]

144 After offering many prayers he said, "Hear me, O Merciful One: no jīva has this quality; it is found in You alone.

145 Seeing me and smelling my stench, even the wretched flee from me; yet You touch someone like me. You are the independent Lord!

146 But I was better off being lowly; now pride will arise in me."

147 The Lord said, "You will never become proud. Chant the name 'Kṛṣṇa! Kṛṣṇa!' constantly.

148 Teach about Kṛṣṇa and deliver the jīvas, and very soon Kṛṣṇa will accept you as His own."

149 Having said this, the Lord disappeared, and the two brāhmaṇas wept in each other's arms, remembering the Lord's qualities.

150 Thus I have told the story of Vāsudeva's deliverance, through which the Lord received the name Vāsudevāmṛta-prada, "the Giver of nectar to Vāsudeva".[27]

151 So I have described the beginning of the Lord's journey: His visit to Kūrma and the deliverance of Vāsudeva.

152 Whoever hears this pastime with faith soon attains the feet of Caitanya.[28]

153 I do not know the beginning or the end of Caitanya's pastimes; I write only what I have heard from the lips of great souls.

154 O devotees, do not hold my offences in this against me: your feet are my only refuge.

155 Praying at the feet of Śrī Rūpa and Śrī Raghunātha, I, Kṛṣṇadāsa, narrate the *Caitanya-caritāmṛta*.

Notes

1. Heading in the edition: "Obeisance to the Lord, 'Vāsudevāmṛta-prada'" (the Giver of nectar to Vāsudeva; see verse 150). ↩
2. The same verse as Ādi 4.2; translation as there. ↩
3. Heading in the edition: the Lord wishes to go alone, so that under the pretext of searching for His elder brother Viśvarūpa He may deliver the south. ↩
4. *Amṛta-pravāha-bhāṣya*: Mahāprabhu knew well that Viśvarūpa had attained perfection (*siddhi*) long before; He only pretended to go in search of him in order to deliver the south. *Anubhāṣya*: see Madhya 9.299–300. ↩
5. *Anubhāṣya*: *haṭha-raṅge* — "into the clutches of a cheat or swindler". ↩

6. Heading in the edition: under the guise of feigned reproach the Lord glorifies the qualities of Nityānanda, Jagadānanda, Dāmodara and others. ↩
7. *Anubhāṣya*: a sannyāsī is the guru of a brahmacārī, so it is not fitting for a brahmacārī to instruct a sannyāsī. ↩
8. The Gauḍīya Maṭha edition reads *doṣāropa-chale*. *Anubhāṣya*: the very qualities by which the Lord was controlled He deliberately called “faults”, and so made known the greatness of His devotees. ↩
9. *Anubhāṣya*: this brāhmaṇa, Kālā Kṛṣṇadāsa, is not the Kālā Kṛṣṇadāsa of Ādi 11.37 (an eternal friend from Vraja, one of the twelve gopālas); this brāhmaṇa later went to Gauḍa (Madhya 10.62–74). ↩
10. *Anubhāṣya*: *leuṭi* — the western (Hindi) word *lauṭ*, “returning”. ↩
11. Her story is told in Madhya 15 (Ṣāṭhī, Sārvabhauma’s daughter, and her husband Amogha). ↩
12. *Amṛta-pravāha-bhāṣya*: the road south runs along the seashore; six krośas from Purī lies the village of Ālālanātha, where the Deity of four-armed Vāsudeva, Ālālanātha, resides. ↩
13. *Amṛta-pravāha-bhāṣya*: *adhikārī* — the chief royal official; Vidyānagara is now called Porabandar. ↩
14. *Anubhāṣya*: the karaṇa caste, into which Rāmānanda was born, was known in Utkala society as “śaukra-śūdras” (śūdras by birth); yet in truth he was a brāhmaṇa — indeed a Vaiṣṇava paramahaṁsa, the guru of brāhmaṇas. And though to the world he was a royal servant, a *viṣayī*, in truth he was a sannyāsī of the highest kind. ↩
15. Heading in the edition: formerly the Bhaṭṭācārya mocked the Vaiṣṇava, thinking him lower than a smārta. *Anubhāṣya*: so the jñānīs and karmīs who turn away from Caitanya mock a Vaiṣṇava: for them sense perception and inference are everything, while the Vaiṣṇava relies on revealed testimony (*śabda-pramāṇa*) and follows the path of *śrauta*. ↩
16. Heading in the edition: later, by Caitanya’s mercy, the Bhaṭṭācārya realised the greatness of the spiritual Vaiṣṇava. ↩
17. *Anubhāṣya*: here the Lord honours a Vaiṣṇava householder: a pure Vaiṣṇava gṛhastha who has taken shelter at Śrī Caitanya’s feet is worthy of worship even from a sannyāsī and is his guru; this the Lord showed by asking Sārvabhauma for his blessing. ↩
18. Heading in the edition: as contradictory attributes meet in Bhagavān, so His devotee is both soft and hard; the verse is from Bhavabhūti’s *Uttara-rāma-carita* (Act 3, verse 27). ↩

19. Rāghava — the descendant of Raghu; Keśava — the slayer of Keśī. The vocative *he* that ends the first two lines is rendered by “O” at their beginning. Heading in the edition: the verse sung by the Lord Himself. *Amṛta-pravāha-bhāṣya*: *rakṣa mām* — “protect me”; *pāhi mām* — “keep me”. ↩
20. *Amṛta-pravāha-bhāṣya*: the essence of the *hlādinī* potency and the essence of the *saṁvit* potency together form *bhakti-śakti*, the power of devotion; whoever receives it by the mercy of Kṛṣṇa or His devotee becomes a supreme devotee. On whomever Mahāprabhu bestowed His mercy, He invested this power and entrusted him with preaching the Vaiṣṇava dharma. ↩
21. *Amṛta-pravāha-bhāṣya*: although Navadvīpa is a *dhāma*, the *nyāya* and *smṛti* śāstras were then especially strong there, and among their teachers many had turned away from the Lord; to deliver them the Lord showed no special power. ↩
22. *Anubhāṣya*: Kūrma-sthāna is Kūrmācala, or Śrīkūrmam, in Ganjam district, eight miles east of Chicacole Road station, where the Deity of Kūrma resides. According to the *Prapannāmṛta*, Jagannātha once carried Rāmānuja there in a single night; at first Rāmānuja took the Deity for a Śiva-liṅga, but then he opened the worship of Kūrmadeva. ↩
23. Heading in the edition: the Lord orders everyone to preach the name of Kṛṣṇa and bhakti as ācāryas. ↩
24. *Anubhāṣya*: to those who wish to give up everything and serve Mahāprabhu, the Lord says, “Stay at home” — that is, give up the pride of being “wholly given to bhajana”; with a householder’s humility chant the name of Kṛṣṇa constantly and preach the pure name, and then the waves of worldliness, the craving for fame, will not overwhelm you. Śrī Rūpa, Sanātana, Jīva, Raghunātha dāsa, Narottama, Madhva and Rāmānuja accepted disciples and wrote books; to regard this as an obstacle to bhakti is an offence. So Śrī Gaurāṅga, the guru of the world, orders everyone to become an ācārya. ↩
25. Heading in the edition: until He returned to Purī, the Lord ordered everyone to preach bhakti as ācāryas. ↩
26. The same verse as Ādi 17.78 (see the *Anubhāṣya* summary there); translation as there. ↩
27. *Amṛta-pravāha-bhāṣya*: this name is among the “hundred names of Śrī Caitanya” composed by Śrī Sārvabhauma. ↩
28. *Anubhāṣya*: Śrī Kṛṣṇa Caitanya awakens consciousness (*caitanya*) in jīvas devoid of it; having gained consciousness and turned to the service of Kṛṣṇa, they in turn as ācāryas awaken it in others — so Śrī Gaurasundara increases the family of Acyuta, spreading the path of *śrauta*. ↩